

A rite of passage

"So the albatross is around your neck..." the resource manager said to Amol. The Albatross' was a code name for what was to be a customised groupware application for senior management. The idea was to make the product robust enough through internal use and then add it to the company's product portfolio.

It was customary or almost mandatory for newly promoted project leaders to spend some time with the project, which never had permanent resources except for the project leader.

Amol wasn't exactly a new employee but he was still getting used to being treated with a mix of awe and sympathetic encouragement over his new role. If the head of the products division was fond of groupware suites, he felt even more strongly about matrix organisation structures. The Albatross project had a resource manager allotting surplus human resources, who got re-allotted the moment a 'billable' activity came along. The project never had any permanently committed resources. So, even though the product idea was promising, it got nowhere.

Hidden in this dour, monochromatic scheme of things was a valuable gem of insight; if only someone could find it.

The key to the puzzle

Amol learned that the early work on the project, including definition and planning, had been meticulously done by some kind souls and there was little reason to revisit it. And even if the project was a revolving door for resources, the resources that got allotted were adequately skilled. So what was it that was acting as a dampener?

Time tracking in Amol's company was decentralised and left to the project leaders. Amol went over previous time sheets

but was quickly overwhelmed by multi-tabbed spreadsheets with funny names. He just could not figure out how much time had been spent on a specific WBS (Work Breakdown Structure) item, leave alone what work output ought to have been produced for the time spent. He was smart enough not to confuse this with the grand project plan that came with its Gantt and Resource charts. The project plan itself had been scrupulously maintained by successive project leaders, except that it had been re-baselined so many times that the original baseline was part of history.

Grandfatherly advice

Amol's grandfather was a great source of inspiration to him. Amol remembered, but never understood, his oft-repeated quote: "If you want something done, give it to a busy man." It took a long walk with his grandfather one evening for Amol to grasp its meaning.

It was while watching the nine o'clock news hour debate that the last piece of the puzzle fell into place for Amol. In all the historical data he had been sifting through, starkly missing was the clarity at the point where the rubber meets the road—how does individual contributors' time get spent and what output do they attribute to it? What he needed was a tool that could be consistently used to gather and study this information. Only then would conventional project management be meaningful, hypothesised Amol.

Gnotime

No, this is not a typo but a GNOME tool for tracking time. Amol knew about the tool but was trying it out in a project management context for the first time. It was important to apply the tool to the situation in an appropriate manner.

Amol shared his hypothesis

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